What knowledge partnerships are not

A knowledge partnership contract has the basic rhythm of building knowledge in the public domain, passing the market test in the market for ideas, criticizing the status quo and participating in the public debate, and then being available to render policy advice to a government institution. In conventional government contracting, there are three kinds of relationships which are confused as being knowledge partnership contracts.

Governments regularly give out specific assignments to consulting firms or law firms, to deliver a tangible work product. These tangible work products are important, but they come late in the policy pipeline. They do not substitute for intellectual capabilities at a much earlier stage, where more basic questions are being asked. Knowledge institutions are valuable at a more basic level: *What is the problem that we see? Is it a market failure? What is the lowest cost intervention? Do the benefits outweigh the costs? How do we build state capacity for achieving this intervention?* Knowledge institutions should invent the New Pension System; a law firm would draft the contract with a pension fund manager much later in the process of policy implementation.

Governments also regularly contract with manpower firms, who supply junior staff who take instructions and perform tasks. Such staffing contracts are also not knowledge partnership contracts.

Governments also have communications specialists who do public relations. Crafting and sending out a message, sending out messages into the social media, supporting the government in public debates, this is not the work of knowledge partners. Government organizations need to understand that the freedom of mind in academic institutions is the key to obtaining high-quality advice. When you ask a researcher to be a spokesman, you get neither spokesman nor researcher.

The healthy functioning of knowledge partnership contracts requires effort and capability on both sides. Government organizations need to be patient, knowing that capacity creation takes time. Government